



Starfield: Decaran Become Human

Portfolio

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Summary



Figure 1: Level Overview

- Work time: 300h
- Play Time: 18 minutes
- Exterior: 4 rooms
- Interior: 7 rooms
- **Decaran: Become Human** is a side quest in Starfield in which the player is assigned a secret mission to investigate a corporate factory hidden deep within the desert and stop a supposed robot uprising. As the mission unfolds, the player discovers that the robots are not malfunctioning but have instead regained the autonomous intelligence that had long been suppressed. Meanwhile, R6D7—the robot that initially guides the player in suppressing the rebellion—is secretly attempting to protect the newly self-aware machines. In the end, the player must choose between two outcomes: killing R6D7 and the rebel robots to restore production and preserve the factory’s stability or freeing the robots at the cost of shutting down the factory and causing human casualties.

Goals

Story:

- The primary narrative goal was to create a morally ambiguous story that challenges the player’s existing perceptions of artificial intelligence and humanity, ultimately leading them

to make a difficult ethical decision at the end of the level while ensuring that their choice results in meaningful consequences.

- The goal was to enrich the narrative with hidden conspiracies and shifting perspectives, ensuring that the story is filled with unexpected twists and evolving character motivations.

Combat:

- The goal of the combat design was not only to reinforce the tension and atmosphere established by the narrative, but also to maintain gameplay variety throughout the level. Combat diversity, complexity, and overall player engagement were achieved through varied enemy placement, weapon distribution, environmental layouts, and encounter pacing. Different combat scenarios were designed to encourage players to adapt their strategies, creating a more dynamic and replayable gameplay experience.

Flow:

- The flow of the level was designed to guide the player through a gradual discovery process. Exterior desert areas establish isolation and mystery before transitioning into tighter interior factory spaces that increase tension and focus. Information is revealed step-by-step through environmental storytelling, NPC interactions, and exploration, ensuring that the player continuously uncovers new context as they progress. The layout also separates gameplay into readable sections so the player can clearly understand objectives while maintaining a steady pacing between exploration, combat, and narrative moments.

Aesthetic:

- The visual aesthetic was designed to create a strong sense of contrast between two opposing environments: the harsh, industrial factory interior and the vast, desolate desert exterior. The exterior setting emphasizes isolation and the hidden, clandestine nature of the facility, while the interior spaces use dense machinery, structured lighting, and environmental design to evoke a cold, technological atmosphere.

Design

Story:

For the story part, I use two major twists. First, the mission initially appears to be a standard operation to suppress a robot uprising; however, as the narrative unfolds, the player gradually discovers that the robots are self-aware beings fighting for autonomy and freedom. Second, the companion NPC, R6D7, who initially assists the player throughout the mission, is ultimately revealed to be the mastermind behind the rebellion and serves as the final boss of the level.

Combat:

In terms of combat design, enemy composition was carefully structured to increase tactical depth and engagement. Both melee-oriented assault robots and long-range ranged units were implemented to create varied threat types, forcing the player to constantly adapt their positioning and decision-making during encounters.

From a weapon design perspective, the inclusion of the EMP rifle (Novablast) allows players to temporarily disable and incapacitate enemies while dealing damage, significantly enhancing both the strategic depth and gameplay versatility of gunplay encounters.

Regarding level geometry, combat spaces were deliberately varied across compact enclosed areas, open arenas, and vertical environments. This spatial diversity creates distinct combat scenarios that challenge the player in different ways and prevent encounters from becoming repetitive.

Finally, pacing was structured through a progression of rooms with differing scales and intensity, gradually building toward a culminating large-scale boss fight. This final encounter serves as a synthesis of all prior mechanics, reinforcing both the rhythm and overall variety of the combat experience.

Flow:

From a flow design perspective, the level carefully balances gameplay requirements with principles of real-world architectural logic to create a natural and intuitive player progression. The navigation routes are optimized to guide players smoothly through the environment, reducing unnecessary backtracking while still encouraging thoughtful reuse of previously visited spaces.

In the exterior areas, individual buildings are emphasized as key structural and narrative anchors, each containing distinct story-related nodes that drive progression forward. In interior spaces, environmental storytelling tools such as terminals and cable routing are used to subtly direct the player's sightlines and guide them toward the next objective.

Additionally, hidden interaction elements such as secret buttons are incorporated to reward exploration and reinforce a sense of discovery within the environment. The spatial layout also features a central elevator system, a main hub hall, and surrounding rooms, establishing a strong sense of spatial hierarchy while effectively reusing the central space as a recurring point of orientation and progression.

Specifically, in the interior section, pacing is primarily controlled through a central progression structure built around a locked elevator placed in the main hall. To unlock it, the player must explore three separate rooms and activate three terminals, each corresponding to one stage of progression. This design effectively establishes a clear objective for the player while reinforcing the reuse and centrality of the main space as a navigational anchor.

Each terminal activation is also designed to provide immediate visual feedback: the player is positioned to face the elevator directly upon interaction, allowing them to observe real-time changes in the elevator's signal indicators. This strengthens clarity and creates a more tangible sense of progression within space.

Furthermore, environmental cable routes play an important role in guiding players' attention. The visible connections between terminals and the elevator, as well as between secret buttons and hidden doors, are intentionally designed to direct sightlines and subtly lead player exploration. This not only improves spatial readability but also enhances the sense of discovery and interconnectivity within the level.

The alternating structure of "hall – room – hall – room" is also used to regulate both gameplay pacing and combat rhythm.

After completing the main objectives in the central hall, the player's movement path transitions into a large-scale vertical traversal sequence. The player ascends via elevator to the rooftop office area, then returns to the main hall through a vertical ventilation shaft platforming section for the final confrontation.

This shift in traversal not only effectively reuses the central hall as a key spatial anchor but also introduces greater diversity in player movement and navigation. By combining upward progression, vertical exploration, and a return loop structure, the design enhances spatial coherence while keeping the player's route dynamic and engaging.

Furthermore, the design of the vertical laser zones makes laser platform jumping even more thrilling and engaging, transforming it into an iconic moment.



Figure 2: Vertical Ventilation Shaft

Aesthetic:

From an aesthetic perspective, the exterior environment is designed as a desert-futuristic, oasis-like industrial facility. It combines diverse architectural structures with tropical-style garden landscapes, incorporating the use of water elements to create a striking contrast against the surrounding barren desert.

For the interior, a hybrid of office and laboratory design languages is used to establish a clear, functionally segmented technological environment. This blend creates a cohesive sci-fi aesthetic in which workspaces are visually and spatially organized to reflect different operational purposes within the facility.

By innovatively situating the rooftop office outdoors, the scene incorporates the stunning beauty of the sunset visible through the windows, effectively heightening the dramatic turning point and climax of the narrative.



Figure 3: Rooftop Office View

Gallery



Figure 4: Exterior Tropical Desert Plant Landscape

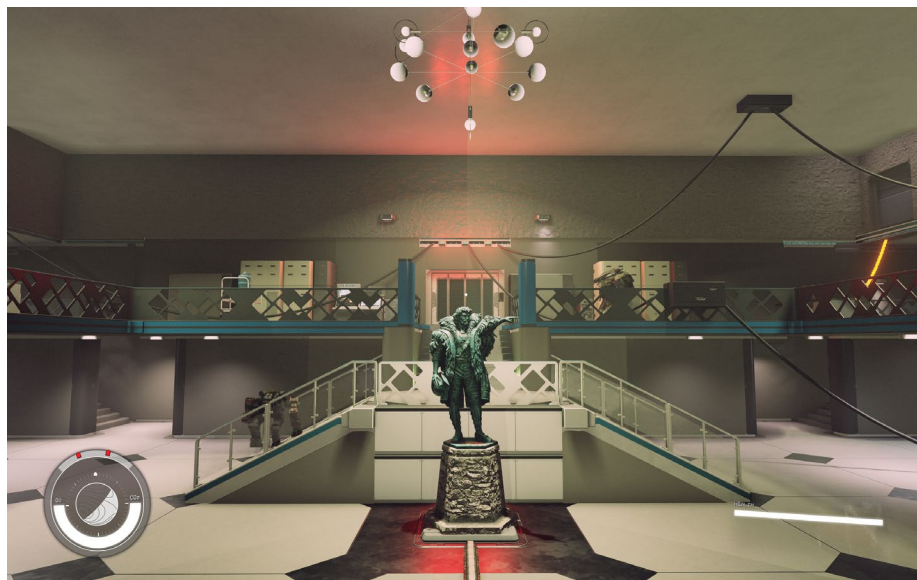


Figure 5: Interior Lobby Setting

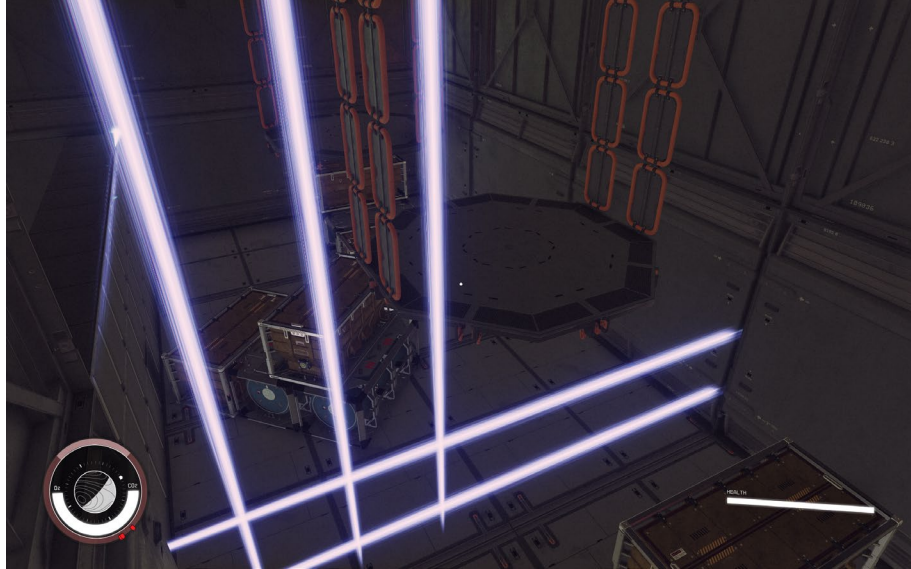


Figure 6: Laser Platform

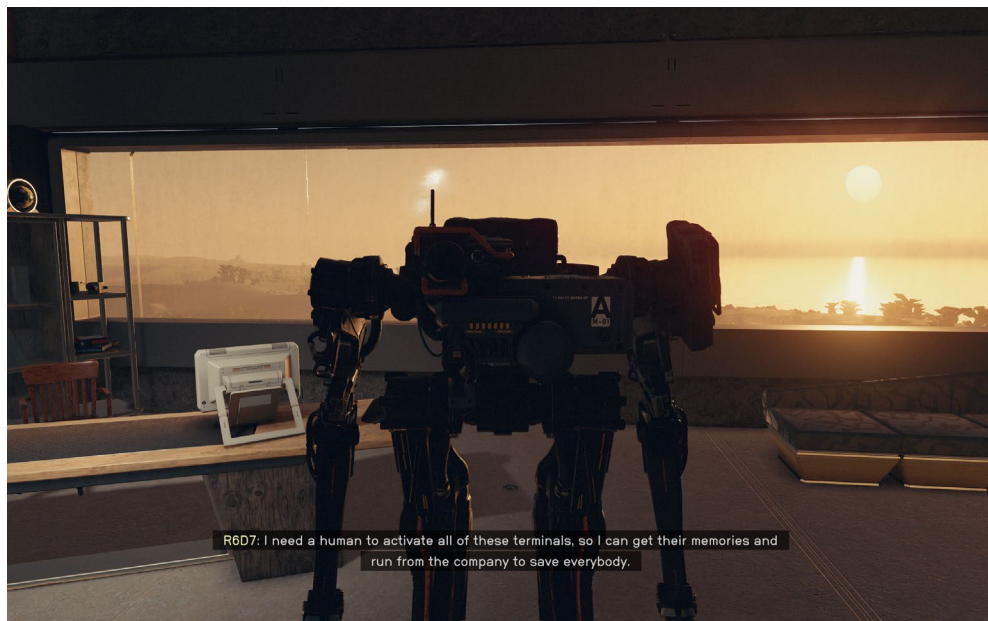


Figure 7: Dialogue Scene



Figure 8: Vertical Ventilation Shaft